

CHINA BOUND TRAVEL RADAR

Week of May 29, 2026 - Premium Pass Only - chinaboundtravel.com

■ ALERT

China's new 144-hour visa-free transit now includes 27 more ports—check your entry city before you fly.

VISA/POLICY

As of May 15, 2026, the 144-hour visa-free transit policy expanded to include Chengdu Tianfu, Xi'an, and Kunming airports, plus 24 other ports. You must have a confirmed onward ticket to a third country and stay within the designated region. No visa needed for most nationalities—just passport and a smile.

SCAM ALERT

Watch for the 'tea ceremony invitation' near Wuhou Shrine—a friendly local invites you for 'free tea,' then you're stuck with a 500 RMB bill. Red flag phrase: 'My uncle owns a tea shop nearby, come try real Sichuan tea.'

ON THE GROUND

Skip the panda base queue—go to Dujiangyan Panda Valley instead. It's 45 min north, half the tourists, and you can volunteer to prep bamboo for 200 RMB. Your Insta will thank me.

CROWD CONDITIONS

Chengdu Research Base of Giant Panda Breeding: packed by 9 AM, wait 40+ min for cubs. Leshan Giant Buddha: moderate crowds, but stairs are bottlenecked by 11 AM. Jinli Ancient Street: elbow-to-elbow after 6 PM—hit it at opening for a chill stroll.

CITY OF THE WEEK: CHENGDU

Hit the teahouses in Renmin Park before 3 PM to snag a bamboo chair and 15 RMB jasmine tea—after that, it's a tourist zoo. For legit mapo tofu, skip the chains and head to Chen Mapo Tofu on West Yulong Street; the line moves fast. Use the Chengdu Metro app for QR codes—cash is still king at street stalls, so carry 100 RMB in small bills.